

Change Navigation Strategic Framework

An enterprise operating model for assessing, planning, activating, and reinforcing high-impact change.

Executive Summary

This framework is not a communications template. It is a strategic change navigation system. Communication is one activation lever, but successful change also requires clear ownership, risk assessment, stakeholder alignment, functional impact translation, leader readiness, adoption support, reinforcement, and measurement.

The framework was developed through the Cai Change Navigation & Communication Framework and adapted into a scalable model for high-impact change across Customer Care and, over time, the enterprise. Cai remains the proof point: the process protects trust by defining a durable narrative, equipping leaders before broad exposure, setting language guardrails, and reinforcing adoption after launch.

Use this framework before communication plans are built. The goal is to help teams make the right decisions about risk, sequencing, ownership, enablement, and measurement so change lands clearly and responsibly.

Core principle
Reach never comes before readiness.

What this framework helps teams decide

Decision area	What the framework clarifies
Risk level	Whether the change is low, medium, high, or enterprise-critical.
Decision rights	Who owns, approves, advises, enables, and reinforces the change.
Functional impact	How the same change lands differently by function, role, and level.
Narrative and guardrails	What story should anchor the change and what must not be misunderstood.
Activation sequence	What needs to happen before, during, and after launch.
Leader readiness	What leaders need before Team Members or broader audiences hear the change.
Reinforcement and measurement	How the team will know whether the change is understood, adopted, and working.

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When to Use This Framework

- Use this process when a change meets one or more of the following conditions:
- The change impacts frontline work, customer experience, or leader routines.
 - The change introduces AI, automation, new tooling, new workflows, or role expectations.
 - The change could create fear, speculation, or confusion if the narrative is unclear.
 - The change requires multiple audiences to understand different levels of detail.
 - The change may be discussed internally, externally, or across enterprise channels.
 - The change needs sustained adoption, not one-time awareness.

How to use this framework

Start with the Decision Flow to classify the change and determine the required level of rigor. Then use Functional Impact Translation to understand how the change lands by function before finalizing the narrative, cascade, enablement, and activation roadmap.

Outputs for the Framework

Output	Purpose
Change Charter	Defines the strategic intent, outcome, owner, timeline, and scope
Strategic Narrative	Creates the durable story leaders and teams can anchor to. Defines what the change is, what it is not, what does not change, and the durable principle that anchors the work.
Persona Impact Map	Clarifies how each level is impacted and what support each group needs.
Risk Map	Assesses operational, people, adoption, narrative, and external risk
Tenets and Guardrails	Defines how the organization should speak about the change and what language to avoid.
Stakeholder Alignment Plan	Ensures partners pressure-test and align to the narrative before activation.
Change Enablement Plan & Adoption Strategy	Turns the framework into a sequenced rollout, leader cascade, training plan, and reinforcement model.
Activation Roadmap	Sequences communications, training, huddles, office hours, and support
Leader Enablement System	Gives leaders the language, context, and resources to support teams.
Measurement and Feedback Loop	Tracks understanding, confidence, behavior, sentiment, and operational outcomes
Reinforcement and Measurement Plan	Defines how adoption, understanding, and confidence will be tracked after launch.

Framework at a Glance

Step	Focus	Key Question	Primary Output
0	Define the Strategic Change	What business outcome does this change support? What behavior, decision, workflow or mindset needs to change?	Before anyone writes a narrative, the framework should require teams to define the strategic change.
1	Start with the Core Narrative	What is the one story everyone must anchor to?	Core narrative and durable principle
2	Map Personas and Impact	Who is impacted and what do they need?	Persona impact map
3	Identify Narrative Risks	What stories could people create if we do not guide them?	Narrative risk map
4	Establish Tenets	How do we want to show up?	Communication tenets
5	Create Guardrails and Do / Don't Language	What should we say, avoid, and never imply?	Language standards and guardrails
6	Align Stakeholders and Pressure-Test	Who needs to challenge and validate the narrative?	Aligned framework and documented risks
7	Build the Change Enablement Plan	How do we sequence communication and support adoption?	Change plan and workback
8	Equip Leaders by Level	What does each leader level need to lead well?	Leader toolkits and cascades
9	Reinforce and Measure Adoption	How will we know the change is landing?	Reinforcement and measurement plan
10	Document What Can Be Reused	What should future teams not have to rebuild?	Reusable assets and templates

Define the Strategic Change:

Strategic question	Why it matters
What business outcome is this change supporting?	Connects the work to strategy, not messaging
What behavior, decision, workflow, or mindset needs to change?	Clarifies adoption
What will be different after this change is successful?	Defines the future state
What could make this fail?	Surfaces risk early
Who owns the outcome?	Prevents Comms from becoming the default owner
What must be true before we activate?	Creates readiness gates
What feedback will tell us whether this is landing?	Builds the improvement loop

Decision Flow: From Change Intake to Activation Path

Purpose

This decision flow helps teams determine how to approach a change before building a narrative, communication plan, training plan, or activation roadmap. It is a decision-support tool, not an approval checklist. It helps teams slow down early so they can move with more clarity later.

Core principle

Reach never comes before readiness. High-reach channels should wait until leaders are equipped, the narrative is stable, and support paths are clear.

Decision Flow Map

Sequence	Decision Point
1	Change identified
2	Define strategic intent
3	Identify change type
4	Map impacted functions and roles
5	Assess risk and readiness
6	Classify the change path
7	Map stakeholders and decision rights
8	Translate functional impact
9	Build the strategic narrative and guardrails
10	Build the activation roadmap
11	Apply readiness gates
12	Activate, support, and reinforce
13	Measure, learn, and improve

Decision Flow Steps

Step	Decision	Key questions	Output	Pause signal
1	Define strategic intent	What is changing? Why now? What business outcome does this support? What should be different after the change lands?	Change Charter	The change cannot be explained in plain language.
2	Identify change type	Is this a tool, workflow, policy, org, staffing, product, AI, automation, customer experience, compliance, or operating model change?	Change Type Classification	The team is treating the change as “just an update,” but it changes work, expectations, systems, or customer experience.
3	Map impacted functions and	Which functions are directly	Impacted Function + Role	Impacted teams are not

	roles	impacted? Which are indirectly impacted? Who must lead, approve, enable, or adopt the change?	Map	represented in planning.
4	Assess risk and readiness	What could go wrong operationally, technically, legally, reputationally, or from a Team Member experience standpoint? Are leaders ready?	Risk and Readiness Assessment	Any high-risk category lacks an owner or mitigation plan.
5	Classify change path	Is this low, medium, high, or enterprise-critical change? What level of activation is required?	Recommended Change Path	The path is being chosen based on speed or preference, not risk.
6	Map stakeholders and decision rights	Who owns the outcome? Who approves? Who advises? Who enables? Who must be informed?	Stakeholder and Decision Rights Map	Reviewers are named, but decision owners are unclear.
7	Translate functional impact	How does the same change land differently by function, role, and level?	Functional Impact Translation	The plan assumes one audience experience when the impact varies by function.
8	Build narrative and guardrails	What is the durable story? What should people not misunderstand? What language should we use or avoid?	Strategic Narrative + Guardrails	The narrative cannot answer what is changing, why, and what does not change.
9	Build activation roadmap	What needs to happen before, during, and after launch? What communication, training, huddles, resources, demos, or office hours are needed?	Activation Roadmap	The timeline only includes send dates, not readiness, training, support, or reinforcement.
10	Apply readiness gates	Are leaders equipped? Are resources ready? Are support paths clear? Is the message stable?	Go / Pause Decision	Broad activation is planned before leaders can explain the change.
11	Activate and reinforce	How will the change go live? How will questions, issues, and confusion be handled?	Launch + Support Plan	There is no escalation path, issue owner, or post-launch support plan.
12	Measure and learn	How will we know whether the change landed? What should be reused or improved?	Measurement + Learning Summary	The plan ends at launch.

Change Path Classification

Change path	Use when	Required strategic outputs	Typical activation volume
Low	Awareness-only update; minimal behavior change; low sensitivity; no training required.	Change summary, audience list, owner, timing, single message or update.	1–2 touchpoints
Medium	Defined audience; some workflow, tool, process, timing, or expectation change; moderate support needed.	Change charter, risk scan, stakeholder map, audience impact map, leader note, FAQ or job aid, reinforcement reminder.	3–6 touchpoints
High	Daily work changes; leader translation required; training needed; AI, automation, customer impact, HR, legal, technical, or narrative risk present.	Full change plan, risk map, functional impact map, stakeholder alignment, narrative, guardrails, leader toolkit, training/resources, activation roadmap, feedback loop.	6–12+ touchpoints
Enterprise-critical	Cross-functional, executive-visible, external, regulatory, workforce, reputational, major customer experience, or operating model impact.	Executive sponsor alignment, decision map, full strategic framework, Legal/HR/PR review, leader cascade, role-based enablement, stabilization plan, measurement dashboard, retrospective.	Multi-phase roadmap

The communications count is not the starting decision. It is an outcome of risk level, functional impact, audience readiness, and activation needs.

Risk and Readiness Screen

Risk category	Low	Medium	High
People / role impact	No role or expectation change.	Expectations shift or new behavior is needed.	Role, staffing, pay, reporting, performance, or job security implications.
Workflow impact	No change to daily work.	Some steps or routines change.	Daily work changes materially.
Customer / partner impact	No visible customer or partner impact.	Indirect customer, vendor, candidate, or partner impact.	Direct customer, pet parent, vendor, candidate, or partner experience impact.
Tool / system impact	No system change.	Existing tool changes or new feature added.	New system, replacement system, outage risk, rollback risk, or production dependency.
AI / automation sensitivity	Not applicable.	Tool supports work or self-service.	Could be interpreted as replacement, deflection, surveillance, or reduced human judgment.
Training requirement	No training needed.	Job aid, demo, or light walkthrough.	Required training, practice, certification, or behavior change.
Leader readiness	Leaders already aligned and equipped.	Some leader questions remain.	Leaders may learn at the same time as impacted Team Members.
Legal / compliance / HR sensitivity	No review needed.	Review may be helpful.	Legal, HR, regulatory, policy, licensing, fairness, or confidentiality risk.
External visibility	Internal only.	Possible cross-functional visibility.	Press, social, employer brand, enterprise storytelling, customer, vendor, or reputational risk.
Timeline stability	Flexible and clear.	Some timing uncertainty.	Compressed, changing, or launch-driven before readiness is confirmed.

Escalation rule

Treat the change as High until mitigated if any of these areas are High: people/role impact, AI or automation sensitivity, Legal/HR/compliance sensitivity, external visibility, leader readiness, or customer/partner impact. Treat the change as Medium-High if three or more categories are Medium.

Decision Rights Map

Stakeholder alignment happens twice: early to clarify ownership and decision rights, and later to pressure-test the narrative, risks, and activation plan.

Role	Owns	Required when
Executive Sponsor	Strategic intent, risk tolerance, final direction.	High or enterprise-critical change.
Business / Product Owner	Scope, timeline, capability, outcome.	Any change tied to a product, system, workflow, or business process.
Program / Project Owner	Roadmap, milestones, dependencies, execution tracking.	Medium, high, or multi-phase change.
Functional Owner	Role-specific impact, feasibility, adoption needs.	Any impacted function.
Operations Owner	Workflow readiness, leader routines, adoption signals.	Any operational or frontline change.
HR / People Partner	Role, staffing, fairness, engagement, leader coaching, Team Member impact.	Any people, role, org, or sensitive change.
Legal / Compliance Partner	Legal risk, approved language, regulatory or professional boundaries.	Legal, regulated, veterinary, privacy, or external-risk change.
L&D / Instructional Design Partner	Learning needs, training, practice, job aids, learning measurement.	Any change requiring new skills, knowledge, or behavior.
Communications Partner	Narrative architecture, sequencing, audience clarity, channel strategy.	Any change requiring broad understanding, trust, or leader enablement.

Data / Analytics Partner	Measurement, reporting, adoption signals, success metrics.	Any change requiring adoption, performance, or outcome tracking.
People Leaders	Translation, reinforcement, escalation, local adoption.	Any change impacting Team Members.
Impacted Team Members / SMEs	Practical feasibility, testing, feedback, adoption barriers.	Any change affecting daily work.

Readiness Gates

Gate	Readiness question	Decision
Change clarity gate	Can we explain what is changing, why, who is impacted, and what success looks like?	Proceed / clarify
Risk gate	Have we classified risk and assigned mitigation owners?	Proceed / mitigate
Decision rights gate	Are owners, reviewers, approvers, and escalation paths clear?	Proceed / align
Functional impact gate	Do we understand how the change lands differently by function and role?	Proceed / translate
Narrative gate	Is the story clear, durable, and unlikely to create avoidable fear or confusion?	Proceed / revise
Leader readiness gate	Can leaders explain the change, answer expected questions, and reinforce next steps?	Proceed / equip
Enablement gate	Are training, job aids, FAQs, support paths, and resources ready?	Proceed / prepare
Channel gate	Are we using channels that match readiness and risk?	Proceed / adjust
Launch support gate	Are issue owners, rollback paths, office hours, or escalation channels ready?	Proceed / hold
Learning gate	Is there a plan to measure, listen, update resources, and capture lessons?	Proceed / build loop

Functional Impact Translation

Purpose

Functional Impact Translation helps teams understand how a change lands differently across functions, roles, and levels. The same change may create different work for Product, Operations, HR, Legal, Finance, Data, Engineering, L&D, and frontline leaders. This section prevents teams from assuming one message, one resource, or one activation path will work for every impacted group.

Important guardrail

Functional competencies should not be used here to evaluate individual performance. In this framework, they are used to understand the work: what the function owns, what may change, what risk may appear, what support may be needed, and what role that function should play in activation.

How to Use Functional Impact Translation

Step	Action	Output
1	Identify impacted functions.	Functional list.
2	Identify each function's role in the change.	Sponsor, owner, approver, enabler, impacted user, adjacent audience.
3	Identify how work changes by function.	Functional impact notes.
4	Identify decisions or behaviors that must shift.	Adoption requirements.
5	Identify risks if the function is missed.	Functional risk signals.

6	Identify support needed.	Training, resources, leader enablement, data, legal review, operational support.
7	Feed findings into the activation roadmap.	Function-specific activation plan.

Role in the Change

Role in change	Description	Typical support needed
Executive Sponsor	Sets direction, risk tolerance, and strategic intent.	Executive narrative, decision brief, risk view.
Business / Product Owner	Owns scope, timing, capability, business outcome.	Change charter, roadmap, stakeholder map.
Program Owner	Coordinates execution, dependencies, decision follow-through.	Activation roadmap, milestones, risk log.
Functional Owner	Owns how the change lands in their function.	Functional impact map, readiness plan.
Approver / Reviewer	Validates accuracy, risk, language, or compliance.	Review packet, decision deadline.
Enabling Partner	Builds support materials, training, analytics, process, or tools.	Workstream plan, asset list.
People Leader	Translates, reinforces, and escalates.	Leader toolkit, huddle guide, FAQ.
Impacted Team Member	Adopts the change in day-to-day work.	Clear explanation, training, job aid, support path.
Adjacent Audience	Needs awareness because work connects to the change.	Awareness message, reference resource.

Enterprise Functional Impact Taxonomy

Functional family	Functions included	Primary change lens	Key questions	Likely outputs
Product and Customer Experience	Product Management, Product Design, Technical Product Management, Site Experience	Customer journey, product strategy, roadmap, usability, technical constraints.	Does this alter the customer or user journey? Does it affect roadmap, prioritization, user experience, metrics, or customer behavior?	Product brief, customer journey impact, roadmap notes, UX review, success metrics.
Engineering and Technical Delivery	Software Engineering, Software Engineering People Leader, Infrastructure Engineering, Quality Engineering, Technical Product Management, Technical Program Management, Data Engineering, ML Engineering	Systems, architecture, release readiness, testing, performance, reliability, security, technical debt.	Does this affect system behavior, integrations, data flows, observability, testing, incident response, security, or fallback plans?	Technical readiness plan, UAT plan, rollback plan, release notes, support model, war room plan.
Data, Analytics, and Science	Analytics, BI Engineering, Data Engineering, Data Science, Research Science, ML Engineering	Measurement, data quality, dashboards, model quality, insights, governance.	What data will show whether this is working? Are definitions, dashboards, models, data pipelines, and reporting owners ready?	Measurement plan, dashboard, metric definitions, data quality checks, adoption reporting.
Program and Project Execution	Program Management, Project Management, Technical Program Management	Dependencies, sequencing, milestones, risk management, decision tracking.	Who owns the roadmap? What dependencies, blockers, decision gates, and escalation paths exist?	Roadmap, RACI, dependency tracker, risk log, decision log, status cadence.
Operations and Frontline Execution	CC Operations, FC Operations, Site Experience, Instock	Daily workflow, staffing, leader routines, quality, safety, customer experience, adoption.	What changes in daily work? Are leaders ready to coach it? Are staffing, SLAs, support paths, and feedback loops clear?	Operational readiness plan, leader toolkit, huddle guide, SOP update, escalation path.
People, Talent, and Organizational Support	HRBP, Recruiting, Recruiting Coordinator, TA Marketing, Executive Assistant	Role impact, Team Member experience, candidate experience, leader support, confidentiality, logistics.	Does this affect roles, reporting, hiring, compensation, engagement, org design, scheduling, or sensitive people information?	HR review, leader talking points, 1:1 guidance, FAQ, candidate/TM experience plan, confidentiality guidance.
Commercial, Vendor, Supply Chain, and Finance	Category Management, Private Brands Sourcing, Instock, Finance Business Partner	P&L, vendors, forecasting, inventory, contracts, budgets, assortment, supply.	Does this affect vendors, pricing, assortment, inventory, purchasing, forecasting, contracts, or financial planning?	Vendor plan, financial impact view, sourcing timeline, inventory plan, category impact summary.
Legal, Compliance, and Professional Judgment	Legal Counsel, Veterinary Professional	Legal risk, regulatory boundaries, licensing, professional standards, customer trust.	Does this require legal review, professional judgment, licensing considerations, approved language, auditability, or clinical/compliance guardrails?	Legal review, approved language, compliance notes, clinical/professional guidance, escalation criteria.

Change Navigation Framework

Learning, Creative, Brand, and Storytelling	Instructional Design, Marketing Creative, Studio Post Production, TA Marketing, Product Design	Learning design, behavior change, brand consistency, content quality, internal/external storytelling.	Is this awareness, understanding, enablement, or behavior change? What training, content, creative, or brand standards are needed?	Learning plan, training, job aid, content brief, creative assets, brand/storytelling guardrails.
Executive and Administrative Enablement	Executive Assistant, Program Management, HRBP, Finance	Executive readiness, meeting cadence, decision prep, logistics, confidentiality.	Which leaders need preparation? What decisions need time on calendars? What materials are needed before leadership forums?	Briefing packet, meeting plan, decision calendar, follow-up tracker.

Functional Impact Translation Template

Function	Role in change	Direct or indirect impact	What changes for this function?	Decision, behavior, or workflow shift	Risk if missed	Support needed	Owner
[Function]	[Sponsor / Owner / Enabler / Impacted / Adjacent]	[Direct / Indirect]	[Describe impact]	[Describe required shift]	[Describe risk]	[Training, FAQ, dashboard, review, huddle, etc.]	[Name / team]
[Function]							
[Function]							

Functional Translation Questions

Question area	Questions
Work impact	What work changes for this function? What work stays the same? What tasks, handoffs, systems, tools, approvals, or routines are affected? What does this function need to do differently after launch?
Decision impact	Does this change decision rights? Does this change who approves, prioritizes, executes, escalates, or measures the work? Does this introduce new tradeoffs, constraints, or dependencies?
Readiness impact	Does this function need awareness, understanding, enablement, or reinforcement? What must be ready before this function can support or adopt the change?
Risk impact	What could go wrong if this function is not included early? Could the change create confusion, rework, delay, inconsistent execution, compliance risk, customer friction, or Team Member concern?
Measurement impact	What will this function use to know whether the change is working? Who reviews feedback, issues, adoption data, or performance trends?

Function-Specific Decision Prompts

Function family	Ask	Likely outputs
Product and Customer Experience	Does the change affect the customer or user journey? Does it affect roadmap, prioritization, UX, adoption, or product success metrics? What tradeoffs have been made, and who understands them?	Product brief; customer journey impact; UX/content review; success metrics; roadmap notes.
Program, Project, and Technical Program Management	Who owns the roadmap? What dependencies could block launch? What decision gates are needed? What risks need escalation? What mechanisms will track progress and adoption?	Activation roadmap; risk log; decision log; dependency tracker; status cadence.
Engineering, Quality, Infrastructure, and Technical Product	Does this affect production systems, integrations, data flows, access, reliability, observability, or security? What testing, UAT, monitoring, or fallback plans are required?	Technical readiness plan; testing/UAT plan; rollback plan; release notes; war room/support model.
Data, Analytics, BI, Science, and ML	What data will show whether the change is working? Are metric definitions clear? Are dashboards or reports ready? Are there data quality, model quality, or governance risks?	Measurement plan; dashboard; metric definitions; data quality checks; adoption reporting.
Operations and Frontline Execution	What changes in daily work? Who needs to coach, reinforce, or inspect the change? Are staffing, SLAs, quality standards, safety standards, or escalation paths affected?	Operational readiness plan; leader toolkit; huddle guide; SOP update; escalation path; feedback loop.

Change Navigation Strategic Framework

HR, Talent, Recruiting, and Organizational Support	Does this affect roles, reporting, staffing, schedules, pay, performance expectations, hiring, candidate experience, or Team Member engagement? Could it create fairness, confidentiality, or policy concerns?	HR review; leader talking points; 1:1 guide; FAQ; confidentiality guidance; escalation process.
Learning and Instructional Design	Is this awareness, understanding, enablement, or behavior change? Do people need practice or just information? Is the gap caused by knowledge, process, tooling, confidence, or role clarity?	Learning needs assessment; training plan; job aid; knowledge check; practice scenarios; learning measurement plan.
Legal, Compliance, and Professional Judgment	Does this require legal, regulatory, licensing, privacy, policy, or clinical review? Does any language need to be approved? Could this affect customer trust or professional standards?	Legal review; approved language; compliance guidance; clinical/professional guardrails; escalation criteria.
Commercial, Vendor, Supply Chain, and Finance	Does this affect vendors, contracts, pricing, inventory, assortment, sourcing, forecasting, budgets, or P&L? Are external partners affected?	Vendor plan; financial impact summary; forecasting update; inventory/supply plan; sourcing review; business metric dashboard.
Creative, Brand, Content, and Storytelling	Does this need internal storytelling, external storytelling, employer brand support, creative assets, or visual explanation? What language or creative treatment could overstate, confuse, or create risk?	Creative brief; brand guardrails; visual assets; storytelling plan; external review; content timeline.

Functional Impact Output Rules

If the change includes...	Then the activation roadmap should include...
Daily workflow impact	Leader toolkit, job aid, huddle guidance, reinforcement, escalation path.
Tool or system change	Training, demo, UAT summary, launch support, known issues, fallback plan.
AI or automation	Clear support-role framing, human judgment boundaries, leader FAQ, narrative guardrails.
Role, staffing, schedule, pay, or reporting impact	HR review, 1:1 conversation guide, leader talking points, Team Member FAQ.
Customer-facing impact	Customer experience impact review, support guidance, customer-facing language if needed.
Legal, compliance, privacy, or veterinary sensitivity	Legal/professional review, approved language, documentation expectations.
Data, dashboard, metric, or reporting change	Metric definitions, dashboard owner, measurement cadence, data quality checks.
Vendor, inventory, sourcing, or finance impact	Vendor plan, financial impact summary, supply chain readiness, escalation path.
Broad enterprise visibility	Executive narrative, stakeholder pressure test, leader cascade, channel sequencing.
High narrative risk	Guardrails, do/don't language, leader enablement before broad communication.
Behavior change	Training, practice, reinforcement, adoption signals, feedback loop.

Functional Impact Translation summary

This is the bridge between strategy and activation. It ensures the framework does not stop at “who needs a communication” and instead answers “what must be true for this change to work across the enterprise.”

Step 1: Start With the Core Narrative

The core narrative is the foundation of the framework. It is the one story leaders, partners, and impacted teams can anchor to as details evolve. Without a clear core narrative, stakeholders fill gaps with their own assumptions, creating inconsistent language and avoidable fear.

Objective

Define the central truth of the change: what is happening, why it matters, what it enables, what does not change, and what must never be misunderstood.

Core Narrative Questions

- What is changing?
- Why now?
- What does this enable for customers, Team Members, the business, or partners?
- What does not change?
- What should people never misunderstand about this change?
- What principle should stand the test of time as the work evolves?

Builder principle

The core narrative should be durable enough to guide future communication, but flexible enough to hold as product details, timelines, or capabilities evolve.

Core Narrative Template

Prompt	Draft Response
The change is:	
The reason this matters now is:	
This enables:	
This does not change:	
People may misunderstand this as:	
The durable principle is:	
The simplest way to explain this is:	

Example Pattern from Cai

Cai’s narrative anchored to customer choice and human care. The durable principle was that AI at Chewy expands customer choice, not human replacement. This principle provided a consistent anchor for internal communication, leader enablement, and external storytelling guardrails.

Step 2: Map Personas, Impact, and Enablement by Level

Before building communication or enablement plans, define who is impacted, how they are impacted, what they need to understand, and what support they need to successfully adopt or lead the change. This step ensures communication is layered intentionally, not broadcast broadly.

Persona Model

Level	Role	Primary Responsibility in Change	Common Enablement Need
C01	Frontline Team Members / Agents	Execute the change in real interactions and workflows.	Awareness, clarity, practical examples, confidence-building reinforcement
C04	Team Managers	Translate and deliver the message to Teams, lead huddles, coach behavior.	Leader toolkit, talk tracks, FAQs, huddle guides
C05	Ops Leaders	Reinforce consistency across teams and support escalation.	Context, adoption signals, reinforcement expectations
C06	Senior Managers	Monitor execution, ensure readiness, manage adoption across teams.	Strategic context, risk visibility, leader cascade materials
C07	Associate Directors	Bridge strategy and execution and drive accountability.	Narrative guardrails, escalation points, alignment view
C08	Directors	Sponsor and scale across the organization.	Executive summary, risk posture, cross-functional alignment
C09	Senior Directors	Shape narrative and manage enterprise alignment.	Enterprise-level narrative, risk framing, stakeholder alignment
C10+	Executive Leadership	Set direction, risk posture, and external narrative boundaries.	Durable principle, strategic framing, external and reputational risk view

Impact Mapping Questions by Persona

- What changes for this audience?
- What might they fear, question, or misunderstand?
- What do they need to understand before the change goes live?
- What do they need to do differently?
- What support do they need to lead, adopt, or reinforce the change?
- What role do they play in adoption?
- What information is awareness-only, and what requires enablement?

Impact and Enablement by Level

C01 – Frontline Team Members / Agents

Category	Details
Impact	• Directly affected by tools, workflows, and expectations. • Experience the change first in execution. • May feel uncertainty, skepticism, or concern if the why is unclear.
What They Need	• What is changing and what is not changing. • How day-to-day work is impacted. • What they will see and do. • How they are supported. • Why their role remains essential.
Enablement Required	• Awareness-level communication. • Clear, simple messaging. • Visuals or demos where possible.

	• Leader-led huddle reinforcement. • Practical FAQs and support paths.
Primary Objective	• Awareness to understanding to confidence

C04 – Team Managers

Category	Details
Impact	• Responsible for translating and delivering messaging. • Lead huddles and team discussions. • First point of escalation for questions and concerns.
What They Need	• Consistent language and narrative. • Anticipated questions and responses. • How to handle concern or skepticism. • What to reinforce and what to escalate.
Enablement Required	• Leader enablement toolkit. • Huddle guide. • FAQ. • What to say / what not to say guidance. • Escalation paths.
Primary Objective	• Enablement to translation to confidence

C05–C06 – Senior Managers / Operations Leaders

Category	Details
Impact	• Responsible for consistency across teams. • Monitor adoption and execution. • Support escalation, reinforcement, and coaching.
What They Need	• Deeper context behind the change. • Visibility into risks and sensitivities. • Clear expectations for reinforcement. • Insight into adoption signals.
Enablement Required	• Leadership briefing. • Reinforcement expectations. • Adoption signals or dashboards. • Escalation guidance. • Feedback review cadence.
Primary Objective	• Alignment to reinforcement to accountability

C07 – Associate Directors

Category	Details
Impact	• Bridge strategy and execution. • Ensure alignment across multiple teams. • Influence leadership tone and delivery.
What They Need	• Strategic narrative and context. • Clear guardrails and positioning. • Understanding of enterprise implications. • Where leadership sponsorship is required.
Enablement Required	• Strategic alignment session. • Narrative and guardrail overview. • Role clarity in driving alignment. • Decision or escalation points.
Primary Objective	• Strategic alignment to ownership

C08 – Directors

Category	Details
Impact	• Sponsor and scale the change across the organization. • Ensure consistency across functions. • Represent the initiative broadly.
What They Need	• High-level narrative. • Clear positioning and guardrails.

	• Visibility into risks and perception. • How this supports strategy.
Enablement Required	• Executive summary. • Narrative alignment session. • Cross-functional coordination. • Risk and readiness view.
Primary Objective	• Sponsorship to alignment to scale

C09-C10+ – Senior Directors and Executive Leadership

Category	Details
Impact	• Define direction and intent. • Shape enterprise narrative. • Manage external and reputational risk.
What They Need	• Clear, durable principle. • Confidence in the message. • Awareness of enterprise-level risk. • What should and should not be amplified.
Enablement Required	• Executive alignment. • Narrative validation. • External communication alignment. • Risk posture and decision criteria.
Primary Objective	• Direction to risk management to narrative ownership

Awareness vs. Enablement Requirements

Audience Need	Use When	Typical Outputs
Awareness	Audience needs to know what is changing and where to find more information.	Announcement, summary, FAQ, simple timeline
Understanding	Audience needs context and practical explanation to interpret the change correctly.	Huddle guide, demos, QRG, example scenarios
Enablement	Audience must lead, explain, coach, or execute the change.	Toolkit, talk tracks, training, decision trees, escalation path
Reinforcement	Audience needs repeated support to sustain adoption.	Follow-up comms, pulse checks, huddle loops, updated FAQ

Key insight

Each level requires a different type of support. C01 requires clarity and confidence. C04 requires language and enablement. C05–C06 require alignment and reinforcement guidance. C07+ requires strategic context, sponsorship, and ownership.

Step 3: Identify Narrative Risks

Narrative risk is the gap between what the initiative intends and what people may believe if the communication is unclear. This step identifies the assumptions, concerns, and informal stories that may emerge before they become the dominant interpretation.

Risk Mapping Questions

- What assumptions could people make if they only heard the headline?
- What fear could this create?
- What could be misinterpreted internally?
- What could be misinterpreted externally?
- What water cooler narrative do we need to prevent?
- What narrative would be damaging if repeated by leaders, Team Members, customers, media, or partners?
- What topics require proactive clarification, not reactive reassurance?

Narrative Risk Map Template

Potential Misinterpretation	Audience Most Likely to Believe It	Risk Level	Preventive Message	Owner

Water cooler principle

Informal conversations often shape perception faster than formal communication. A strong framework anticipates the story people might create and gives leaders language to redirect it.

Common Narrative Risk Categories

Risk Category	Common Signal	Communication Response
Replacement risk	People interpret the change as reducing or replacing human contribution.	Name what remains human-led and where people remain essential.
Capability overstatement	People believe the tool can do more than it currently can.	Be clear about current capability, limitations, and what is still evolving.
Channel drift	People assume the change applies to channels or workflows outside scope.	State scope and non-scope directly.
Timing risk	People hear about the change before leaders can answer questions.	Sequence leader enablement before broad exposure.
External misinterpretation	External audiences frame the change differently than internal intent.	Align with PR and external comms before broad storytelling.
Future contradiction	Messaging creates a promise that future evolution may contradict.	Use durable language that can stand the test of time.

Step 4: Establish Communication Tenets

Tenets define how the organization will show up while communicating the change. They are not slogans. They are operating standards that guide decisions across messages, channels, audiences, and phases.

Tenets Should Answer

- How do we want to show up?
- What values must the work protect?
- What standards should hold over time?
- What should remain true even as details evolve?
- What do all partners need to align to before communication begins?

Tenets Builder Template

Tenet	What It Means	How It Shows Up	What It Prevents

Example Tenets

Tenet	Description	Application
Clarity over speed	Getting the right learning and communication matters more than moving fast.	Pause, clarify, and re-communicate when understanding is unclear.
People are partners	Impacted teams are not simply recipients of change.	Involve frontline users in testing, validation, and feedback loops.
This is an us change	Messaging should reinforce shared ownership and shared outcomes.	Avoid language that distances decision-makers from impacted teams.
Stand the test of time	Language should avoid unnecessary reversals or future contradiction.	Avoid overpromising or absolute statements unless they are truly durable.
Own the outcome	If something does not land well, course-correct visibly.	Use feedback to update messaging, FAQs, training, and operations.

Step 5: Create Guardrails and Do / Don't Language

Guardrails translate tenets into practical language guidance. They help stakeholders understand what to emphasize, what to avoid, and what must remain consistent across internal and external storytelling.

Guardrail Questions

- What words, claims, or comparisons should we avoid?
- What should we never imply?
- What language needs to stay consistent across audiences?
- Where could wording create fear, confusion, or expectation gaps?
- What is approved language leaders can confidently repeat?
- What should not be said externally until it has been established internally?

Do / Don't Template

Do	Don't	Why It Matters

Guardrail Types

Guardrail Type	Purpose	Example
Terminology	Protect clarity and avoid inconsistent language.	Use approved product or initiative names consistently.
Role distinction	Avoid implying tools replace or outperform people.	Describe how technology supports work without devaluing human judgment.
Capability boundaries	Avoid overpromising.	Describe current capability separately from future roadmap.
Channel scope	Avoid drift into unrelated channels or workflows.	State whether the change applies to chat, voice, email, app, desktop, or internal workflow.
External storytelling	Protect internal trust and brand consistency.	Do not introduce narratives externally that impacted teams have not heard internally.
Future-proofing	Avoid unnecessary reversals.	Use language that can hold as details evolve.

Step 6: Align Stakeholders and Pressure-Test the Framework

Stakeholder alignment is not an approval layer. It is a structured opportunity to challenge the framework, identify blind spots, validate risks, and ensure the narrative works across audiences and functions.

Placement note: stakeholder alignment happens twice

Use early stakeholder mapping to confirm ownership, decision rights, and functional representation before the narrative is finalized. Use this later pressure-test step to challenge the narrative, validate risks, test sequencing, and confirm readiness before activation.

Strategic Ownership Model

Role	Owns
Executive Sponsor	Strategic intent, risk tolerance, final decision-making
Business / Product Owner	Scope, timeline, capability, business outcome
Operations Owner	Workflow readiness, leader readiness, frontline feasibility
HR / Change Partner	Team Member impact, sensitivity, fairness, change support
L&D Owner	Training, practice, job aids, learning measurement
Communications Owner	Narrative architecture, sequencing, language, channels
People Leaders	Translation, reinforcement, feedback, adoption support
Measurement Owner	Adoption signals, sentiment, operational data, improvement loop

Who to Include

Stakeholder	Point of View They Bring	What to Ask Them
Product / Program Owner	Intent, capability, roadmap, limitations.	What must be true? What should not be promised?
Operations	Workflow reality, leader readiness, frontline impact.	How will this land with teams? What support do leaders need?
HR / Change	Team Member experience, sensitivity, policy implications.	Where could this create fear, confusion, or fairness concerns?
L&D / Training	Learning needs and readiness requirements.	What requires training, practice, or demonstration?
Internal Communications	Enterprise consistency and channel strategy.	Where might this show up in broader forums?
PR / External Communications	External narrative, reputational risk, media context.	Could this be mischaracterized externally?
Legal / Compliance	Regulatory, policy, or risk boundaries.	What must be reviewed or constrained?
Leaders closest to impacted teams	Practical questions, sentiment, local realities.	What will your teams ask first?

Stakeholder WIIFM Map

Use WIIFM to clarify why each stakeholder should engage, what risk they are managing, and what value alignment creates for their function.

Stakeholder	What They Care About	Risk if Not Aligned	Value of Alignment

Pressure-Test Prompts

- What part of this narrative feels vulnerable?
- What would your audience challenge or question?
- What wording could create the wrong expectation?
- Where are we assuming understanding that may not exist?
- What do we need to say earlier, more clearly, or more often?
- What should we hold until leaders are prepared?

Operating principle

Alignment should invite challenge. The goal is not to defend the draft. The goal is to make the framework stronger before it reaches the impacted audience.

Step 7: Build the Change Enablement Plan

The framework becomes operational when it is translated into a change enablement plan. This plan defines who hears what, when they hear it, what support is provided, and how reinforcement happens after launch.

Change Enablement Questions

- Who hears the message first?
- What do leaders need before frontline teams hear it?
- What should be layered over time?
- What should be held until readiness is confirmed?
- Where do training, demos, FAQs, job aids, and reinforcement fit?
- What channels are appropriate at each stage?
- What channels may amplify the narrative before teams are ready?

Recommended Change Navigation Phases

Phase	Intent	Primary Audience	Common Outputs	Exit Signal
Phase 1: Align	Establish narrative, scope, risk, stakeholders, and success criteria.	Core partners and senior leaders	Core narrative, risk map, stakeholder map	Stakeholders aligned on what this is, what it is not, and what does not change.
Phase 2: Prepare	Build communication assets, training strategy, leader materials, and FAQs.	Comms, Product, Ops, HR, L&D	Toolkits, FAQs, demos, job aids, channel plan	Materials are accurate and ready for leader enablement.
Phase 3: Equip Leaders	Prepare leaders before broad exposure.	C07 to C04 leaders	Leader briefings, talking points, huddle guides	Leaders can explain the change clearly and confidently.
Phase 4: Activate	Inform impacted teams and launch required training or resources.	Frontline and impacted teams	Announcements, demos, FAQs, training	Teams understand what is changing and where to get support.
Phase 5: Reinforce	Sustain understanding, gather feedback, and adjust messaging.	All impacted audiences	Huddles, pulse checks, updated FAQs, follow-ups	Questions decrease and reinforcement replaces clarification.

Channel Risk Overlay

Channel Type	Examples	Narrative Risk	Guidance
Leader Enablement	Leader toolkits, leader FAQs, office hours	Low	Safe for early use. Designed to build understanding before broader exposure.
Leader-Led Cascades	Manager emails, huddle talking points, team meeting scripts	Low to Medium	Use once leaders are equipped and reinforcement is expected.
Targeted Team Communication	Role-specific updates, job aids, training notices	Medium	Use after leader enablement with clear support paths.
Narrative-Amplifying Internal Channels	Large newsletters, broad storytelling, spotlights	High	Use only after leader readiness is confirmed and narrative is stable.
Enterprise-Wide Internal Channels	Town halls, enterprise newsletters, all-company channels	Very High	Use only after internal alignment and stability are confirmed.
External Communications	Media, social, employer brand, investor commentary	Critical	Use only after internal and customer stabilization, unless reactive response is required.

Channel principle

The higher the reach and narrative risk of a channel, the higher the required level of leader readiness and message stability.

Activation Roadmap Builder

The activation roadmap turns the decision flow, risk classification, stakeholder alignment, and functional impact translation into an actionable rollout. It is more than a communication calendar. It includes decision gates, leader enablement, training, resources, launch support, reinforcement, and measurement.

Phase	Strategic question	Outputs
Define	What is changing, why, who owns it, and what success looks like?	Change charter, success criteria, owner, scope.
Assess	What is the risk and who is impacted?	Risk score, functional impact map, audience map.
Align	Who must decide, review, enable, and reinforce?	Stakeholder map, RACI, decision rights.
Design	What narrative, guardrails, learning, resources, and support are needed?	Narrative, FAQ, guardrails, learning/resource plan.
Prepare	Are leaders, systems, materials, and support paths ready?	Leader toolkit, job aids, training, escalation path.
Equip	Can leaders and change carriers explain and support the change?	Briefings, huddles, office hours, talking points.
Activate	How does the change go live without creating avoidable confusion?	Launch sequence, communications, resource release.
Stabilize	How will questions, issues, and gaps be handled after launch?	Support plan, office hours, FAQ updates, issue log.
Reinforce	How will adoption be sustained?	Reminders, huddle loops, manager reinforcement, reporting.
Learn	What should improve next time?	Retrospective, updated templates, example library.

Right Cascade Principle

Leader-first does not mean leader-only. It means leaders have context, language, and support before Team Members are asked to interpret the change. The right cascade protects trust because each layer receives the information and enablement needed to support the next layer.

Cascade sequence	Use when	Purpose
Sponsor and core partner alignment	Change is still forming.	Confirm intent, scope, risks, owner, and decision rights.
Functional owner alignment	Impacted functions need to translate the change into work.	Validate feasibility, support needs, and functional risks.
C09/C10+ alignment	Enterprise, external, legal, HR, AI, or reputational risk exists.	Confirm risk posture and strategic narrative.
C07/C08 alignment	Leaders must sponsor, scale, or coordinate across teams.	Equip leaders with context, guardrails, and escalation paths.
C05/C06 enablement	Operational leaders must reinforce and inspect adoption.	Clarify expectations, adoption signals, and support mechanisms.
C04 leader enablement	Managers will deliver huddles, answer questions, or coach behavior.	Provide talk tracks, FAQ, huddle guide, and escalation guidance.
Impacted Team Member activation	The audience needs to understand or adopt the change.	Explain what is changing, what to do, what support exists, and where to ask questions.
Broad awareness	Adjacent or enterprise audiences need context.	Share stable narrative only after leaders and directly impacted teams are ready.
External or enterprise storytelling	The change is stable and internally understood.	Share only after internal adoption signals and leader confidence support it.

Cascade risk signal

If a high-reach channel is planned before leader readiness is confirmed, pause and move back to leader enablement. High visibility should never be the first time impacted teams hear the story.

Step 8: Equip Leaders by Level

Leaders are the primary drivers of adoption. They do not only pass along information. They translate the change, reinforce meaning, answer questions, and shape the informal narrative. Leader enablement must be designed by level.

Leader Enablement Requirements by Level

Level	Leader Role	Primary Need	Recommended Materials	Readiness Signal
C10+ / C09	Set direction and narrative ownership.	Strategic framing and enterprise risk view.	Executive summary, durable principle, risk posture.	Can articulate why the change matters and what must remain consistent.
C08 / C07	Sponsor and align across functions.	Ownership, alignment, and escalation clarity.	Narrative deck, stakeholder map, guardrails, escalation paths.	Can reinforce the narrative and identify where teams need support.
C06 / C05	Drive consistency and reinforcement.	Adoption expectations and feedback signals.	Leader toolkit, reinforcement plan, success signals, FAQ.	Can coach leaders and monitor adoption patterns.
C04	Translate and deliver the message to Teams.	Specific language and practical support.	Huddle guide, talk tracks, what to say / not say, FAQ, demos.	Can lead huddles and answer expected questions confidently.
C01	Adopt and execute the change.	Clarity, confidence, and support.	Announcement, demo, job aid, FAQ, support path.	Can explain what is changing and what they need to do.

Leader Toolkit Standard

- One-page summary of what is changing and why.
- Core narrative and durable principle.
- What this is / what this is not.
- Key dates and sequencing.
- Talking points for team huddles and 1:1s.
- Expected questions and approved responses.
- What to say / what not to say.
- Escalation path for questions, concerns, or exceptions.
- Reinforcement expectations after launch.
- Feedback collection method.

Leader Readiness Checkpoint**Leader Readiness Checkpoint**

Before advancing from leader enablement into broad team-facing storytelling or communication, confirm that leaders are equipped, the narrative is stable, and reinforcement paths are clear. Progression pauses if leader confidence is not met or narrative amplification risk remains elevated.

Readiness Criteria

Criteria	Ready	Needs Work
Leaders have received toolkit and FAQs.		
Leaders have had time to ask questions.		
Leaders can explain what the change is and is not.		
Escalation path is clear.		
Training or demos are available where needed.		
The message is stable and not exploratory.		
High-reach channels are not being used before readiness.		

Step 9: Reinforce and Measure Adoption

Communication does not end at launch. Adoption requires reinforcement, feedback, and visible adjustment. A strong framework defines how understanding will be measured and how messaging will evolve as people experience the change.

Post-Launch Reinforcement Plan

Timing	Goal	Audience	Tactics	Owner
Week 1	Confirm understanding and identify confusion early.	Impacted teams and leaders	Huddles, FAQs, office hours, quick pulse checks	Comms + Ops
Weeks 2–4	Reinforce key behaviors and address recurring questions.	Leaders and frontline teams	Follow-up comms, demos, updated job aids, huddle prompts	Comms + L&D + Ops
30 days	Assess confidence, comprehension, and adoption signals.	Leaders and impacted teams	Pulse survey, huddle survey, escalation review	Comms + Engagement
60–90 days	Sustain adoption and capture lessons learned.	Stakeholders and leadership	Retrospective, success stories, framework updates	Comms + Business Owner

Adoption Signals

Signal Type	Question It Answers	Examples
Understanding	Can people explain the change?	Pulse confidence, huddle survey, Q&A themes
Confidence	Do people feel prepared?	Leader readiness feedback, agent pulse, office hour questions
Behavior	Are people applying the change correctly?	Workflow usage, training completion, QA trends
Sentiment	How does the change feel?	Open-text feedback, escalations, leader observations
Operational performance	Is the change working as intended?	Adoption metrics, customer signals, incident trends

Feedback Loop Cadence

- Collect questions from leaders and impacted teams weekly during launch.
- Review huddle feedback, pulse checks, and escalation patterns.
- Update FAQs and job aids as new themes emerge.
- Share what changed based on feedback to close the loop.
- Document lessons learned for future teams.

Step 10: Document What Can Be Reused

The final step is to capture reusable assets so future teams do not start from scratch. This is how a one-time framework becomes a scalable operating model.

Reusable Asset Library

Asset	Purpose	When to Use
Core Narrative Template	Helps teams define the central story and durable principle.	At the start of any high-impact change.
Persona Mapping Template	Clarifies audience impact and enablement needs by level.	Before communication planning.
Narrative Risk Assessment	Identifies likely misinterpretations and water cooler narratives.	Before drafting messages.
Tenets Builder	Defines how the change should be communicated.	During framework development.
Do / Don't Template	Turns principles into practical language guidance.	Before writing communications.
Stakeholder Alignment Guide	Supports pressure-testing across functions.	Before activation.
Leader Toolkit Template	Equips leaders to communicate and reinforce.	Before team-facing communication.
Change Sequencing Model	Defines who hears what and when.	During communication planning.
Post-Launch Reinforcement Checklist	Supports adoption after launch.	During and after activation.

How to Maintain the Framework

- Assign an owner for the framework and each reusable asset.
- Review templates after major launches and update based on lessons learned.
- Track which projects use the framework and what outputs are created.
- Create a single source of truth for current templates and examples.
- Capture strong examples from completed launches for future reference.

Appendices: Templates and Working Tools

The following templates can be copied into project working documents and completed by the project team.

Appendix A: Change Framework Intake Checklist

Question	Response	Owner
What is the initiative or change?		
Who is the business owner?		
Who is impacted directly?		
Who is impacted indirectly?		
What is the desired behavior or adoption outcome?		
What are the key risks if communication is unclear?		
What is the launch or activation timeline?		
What training or demos are required?		
What leaders must be equipped first?		
What channels are in scope?		
What channels are out of scope?		
What external communication risk exists?		

Appendix B: Core Narrative Worksheet

Narrative Component	Working Draft
What is changing?	
Why now?	
What does this enable?	
What does not change?	
What is the durable principle?	
What should people never misunderstand?	
What is the simplest explanation?	

Appendix C: Persona Impact Worksheet

Audience / Level	Impact	Likely Questions or Concerns	Needs to Understand	Enablement Required	Timing
C01					
C04					
C05/C06					
C07					
C08					
C09/C10+					

Appendix D: Narrative Risk Assessment

Risk	Likely Audience	Impact	Preventive Message	Mitigation Owner

Appendix E: Tenets Builder

Tenet	Meaning	Behaviors It Drives	Risks It Prevents

Appendix F: Do / Don't Language Guide

Topic	Do Say	Do Not Say	Reason

Appendix G: Leader Toolkit Checklist

- Executive summary
- Core narrative
- What this is / what this is not
- Audience impact by level
- Key dates and milestones
- Talking points
- Huddle guide
- FAQs
- What to say / what not to say
- Demo or visual aid, if applicable
- Training expectations
- Escalation path
- Reinforcement expectations
- Feedback collection method

Appendix H: Launch Readiness Checklist

Readiness Question	Yes / No	Notes
Is the core narrative final and aligned?		
Are the tenets and guardrails approved?		
Have narrative risks been identified and addressed?		
Have personas and impact levels been mapped?		
Have leaders received the appropriate toolkit?		
Have leaders had time to ask questions?		
Are training and demos ready, if required?		
Are FAQs and support paths available?		
Is the communication sequence clear?		
Are high-risk channels held until readiness is confirmed?		
Is there a post-launch reinforcement plan?		
Is there a feedback loop and owner?		

Appendix I: Post-Launch Reinforcement Checklist

Action	Owner	Timing
Review incoming questions and escalation themes.		
Update FAQs based on repeated questions.		
Send reinforcement huddle prompts.		
Run pulse or huddle survey.		
Review adoption or usage signals.		
Share “you said / we did” follow-up, if applicable.		
Document lessons learned for future launches.		

Appendix J: Example Application - Cai

The [Cai Change Navigation & Communication Framework](#) applied this process to a customer-facing AI launch. The work began by establishing a durable principle: AI at Chewy expands customer choice, not human replacement. From there, the framework mapped impacted audiences, identified likely misinterpretations, established communication tenets, created guardrails for internal and external storytelling, aligned Product, Operations, HR, PR, and Internal Communications partners, and built a leader-first enablement plan.

The key insight from Cai is that complex AI communication requires more than a message. It requires a system that aligns the narrative, equips leaders, protects informal conversations, and reinforces adoption over time.

A scalable change framework helps teams move from reactive communication to intentional change navigation. It protects trust, clarifies intent, equips leaders, and creates the conditions for adoption. The goal is not only to communicate what is changing. The goal is to help people understand, support, and execute the change with confidence.

Phase	Phase Objective	Primary Vehicles	Audience Detail	Timeframe / Key Milestones	Guardrails & Signals
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Phase 1: Planning & Readiness	Lock narrative, language, and risk posture	Working docs, alignment reviews, limited context-setting storytelling	CC leadership, Product, Ops, Comms	January-early February	No leader cascades. No TM-facing narrative about Cai.
Phase 2: Leader Enablement & Alignment	Equip leaders before Teams hear anything	CC Updates, leader toolkits, office hours	C06+ → C05+ → C04+	Early March (leader cascades complete)	Leaders equipped at least 48 hours before any TM-facing communication.
— Leader Readiness & Narrative Control Checkpoint —					
Before advancing from leader enablement into Team Member- facing storytelling or broad internal communication, Communications conducts a readiness check to ensure leaders are fully equipped and narrative risk is controlled. Progression pauses if leader confidence is not met or narrative amplification risk remains elevated. See Leader Readiness & Hydration Risk Assessment (linked resource) for criteria.					
Phase 3A: TM Voice & Credibility	Build trust before behavior change	Leader-led huddles, internal videos, spotlights	TMs (C01+)	Mid March	No training. No customer exposure. No narrative amplification.
Friends & Family Launch (Tuesday, April 14)					
Phase 3B: Experience Enablement	Prepare TMs for day-one interaction	Pupdates, Mewsletters, huddle guides, FAQs, job aids	TMs (C01+), reinforced through leaders	Late March	Training and resources must be live before activation.
Training Assigned to Emerging Programs (Monday, April 1) Training Assigned to Chat (Monday, April 27) Customer Hydration Begins (Tuesday, May 12 TBD)					
Phase 3C: Activation & Reinforcement	Support live experience and learning	Pupdates, Mewsletters, reinforcement huddles, follow-ups	TMs (C01+) → Enterprise (as needed)	Ongoing reinforcement	
Enabling for desktop and mobile web (TBD)					
Phase 3C: Reinforcement	Huddle surveys / pulse feedback collected	Huddles, Mewsletters	CC C01+	May	Feedback is reviewed regularly and used to adjust messaging, reinforcement cadence, and operational guidance.
Expansion (as applicable) Expanded access, updated Agent experience, continued reinforcement					
Phase 3C: Reinforcement	Communications on expanded access, updated Agent experience, continued reinforcement. Post-launch learning, adjustments	Follow-up communications -Pupdates	CC C01+	After May	Customer exposure only after internal stability and leader confidence.
Enterprise Communication plan (post-stabilization)					

TBD	Launch comms – what, why	Enterprise Dir + monthly meeting	C08+	TBD	Shared by Brenda or Shiv, this can potentially be an email in advance.
TBD	Launch – what, why	Bark & Buzz, can potentially have a video (docuseries style, how we got here)	All Team Members	TBD	
TBD	Update, wins	Town Hall	All exempt TMs FC, CC and all corp	September/October	TBC as an agenda item. We can regroup in August.
— External Communication Guardrail —					
Post-stabilization only: Proactive external communication or storytelling will occur only after Team Members demonstrate understanding and confidence, leaders confirm reinforcement is landing as intended, customer experience signals indicate stability, and early feedback shows the change is operating as designed. Reactive communication, when required, will adhere to the same language standards and guardrails outlined in this framework.					

Appendix K: Cai Change Navigation Case Study

Cai is the proof point for this framework. It showed why high-impact change needs a durable narrative, disciplined cascade, leader enablement, editorial guardrails, and reinforcement after launch. Cai’s core narrative was not only about a customer-facing assistant; it was about customer choice, human care, and trust.

Cai Communication Tenets

Tenet	What it means in practice
Uncompromising about learning and communication	Prioritize the right learning and communication, not just fast communication. When understanding is unclear, pause, clarify, and re-communicate.
Frontline Team Members are partners in testing and readiness	Involve Team Members early. Treat feedback during testing as signal, not noise.
This is an “us” change, not a “they” change	Avoid language that distances decision-makers from Team Members. Reinforce shared ownership and shared outcomes.
Learn from the past and own the outcome	Apply lessons from prior launches. If something fails, own it and course-correct visibly.
Preserve direct access to human support	Technology supports optional self-service for routine needs; customers continue to have a clear path to human support.

Cai Editorial Standards

Do	Don't
Lead with reality and clear boundaries.	Do not use hype language or position technology as a human equivalent.
Reinforce that technology supports Team Members and customers in defined ways.	Do not imply human care, judgment, or empathy can be replaced by AI.
Use plain language and acknowledge uncertainty where it exists.	Do not promise future-state capabilities as current reality.
Keep internal and external messaging aligned.	Do not contradict internal messaging in external storytelling.
Frame AI as changing where effort is spent.	Do not frame AI as improving how well humans care.

Cascade Lesson from Cai

The Cai rollout reinforced that internal trust comes before external storytelling. Leaders need the narrative, guardrails, FAQ, and escalation path before Team Members are exposed to broader storytelling. External or enterprise-amplifying channels should wait until internal understanding is stable.

Appendix L: Future GPT Decision Logic

When this framework becomes a custom GPT, the GPT should guide users through decisions and flag where human judgment is required. It should recommend a path, but it should not approve the change.

GPT Intake Questions

- What is changing, and why now?
- What business outcome does this support?
- Who owns the outcome?
- Who is directly and indirectly impacted?
- Which functions are involved?
- Does this change tools, workflows, role expectations, staffing, customer experience, policy, data, reporting, or decision rights?
- Is AI, automation, legal, HR, privacy, compliance, professional judgment, or external visibility involved?
- What action does the impacted audience need to take?
- Is training required?
- Are leaders already aligned?
- What is the target launch or announcement date?
- What resources already exist?
- Who needs to review or approve?
- How will adoption be measured?

GPT Output

Output	Purpose
Change Charter	Define the strategic intent, owner, outcome, timing, and scope.
Risk and Readiness Assessment	Classify risk and identify mitigation owners.
Recommended Change Path	Right-size the rigor and activation volume.
Stakeholder and Decision Rights Map	Clarify who owns, approves, advises, enables, and is impacted.
Functional Impact Translation	Translate the change by function, role, and level.
Strategic Narrative	Create the durable story and what should not be misunderstood.
Tenets and Guardrails	Define language standards, do/don't guidance, and boundaries.
Activation Roadmap	Sequence alignment, enablement, communications, launch, support, and reinforcement.
Leader Enablement Plan	Equip leaders before broad activation.
Measurement and Feedback Loop	Track understanding, behavior, sentiment, and operational outcomes.
Human Judgment Flags	Surface gaps the GPT cannot resolve.

Human Judgment Flags

- Unclear owner
- Unclear impacted audience
- High risk without mitigation
- Leader readiness gap
- Training gap

- Legal / HR / compliance review needed
- External visibility risk
- Potential AI or automation misinterpretation
- Compressed timeline
- Missing measurement plan
- Missing reinforcement plan